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penetration with or without the evidence of slime and /
but let this be unmistakable this poem
is not consent I do not consent
to my mother to my father to the teachers to
the F.B.I. to South Africa to Bedford-Stuy[9] 105
to Park Avenue to American Airlines to the hardon
idlers on the corners to the sneaky creeps in
cars
I am not wrong: Wrong is not my name
My name is my own my own my own 110
and I can't tell you who the hell set things up like this
but I can tell you that from now on my resistance
my simple and daily and nightly self-determination
may very well cost you your life

1980

9. Abbreviation for the section of Brooklyn called Bedford Stuyvesant, which has a large African American population.

JAYNE CORTEZ
1936–2012

The rich spectrum of Jayne Cortez's artistic and political concerns can be seen just by glancing at titles of her volumes of verse and music-backed poetry recordings. *Festivals and Funerals*, *Scarifications*, *Mouth on Paper*, *Firespitter*, *Coagulations*—these and other titles foreground the importance in Cortez's poetry of performance, ritual, invention, community, embodied assertion, and revolutionary experimentation. When asked about her creative process, Cortez has responded: "I use dreams, the subconscious and the real objects, I open up the body and use organs and I sink them into works, and I ritualize them and fuse them into events. I guess the poetry is like a festival. Everything can be transformed." Juxtaposing vision and desire, dreams and reality, ghostly encounters and political struggle, Cortez's poetry summons this power of collective transformation with distinctive thematic and lyrical force. Even the name of her band (The Firespitters), with which she has performed and recorded much of her poetry, reveals the import of communal struggle: Firespitter, or Kponungo, is a mask from the African Ivory Coast, one said to embody an aggressive supernatural power that would combat any forces that might disrupt the well-being of the community. Hence festivals (carnivalesque transformations) and funerals (irrevocable losses) are bound to each other in Cortez's poetry, and scarification and coagulation constitute a dialectic of trauma and recovery that crystallizes in the ritual of Cortez's blues-laced, African-inspired praise-songs.

Jayne Cortez was born in Arizona on the Fort Huachuca army base where her father was stationed, the middle child between an older sister and younger brother. The public school system was segregated, and she attended a one-room schoolhouse composed mostly of black and Native American children. At age seven, Cortez moved with her family to San Diego for nearly a year to live with her maternal grandmother's family (noting her performative aspirations, Cortez's grandfather took her

aside one day and said, "You want to be an actress like Lena Horne, or somebody") and then migrated to the Watts section of Los Angeles, which provided a community where Cortez encountered instruction in performance: "We played the Dozens, signified, told jokes, and performed for each other. It was an everyday ritual." Cortez also took advantage of the musical atmosphere of her parents' house, where she was exposed to Ella Fitzgerald, Billie Holiday, Lena Horne, Duke Ellington, Count Basie, and Jimmy Lunceford; she "fell in love" with Charlie Parker and Thelonious Monk. Cortez herself played piano, bass, and cello, and took courses in music theory and harmony while attending the Manual Arts High School, where she also studied drawing, painting, and design, and started writing at the age of fourteen.

After high school, Cortez attended Compton Junior College in hopes of becoming an actress, but left school at eighteen when she married jazz saxophonist Ornette Coleman, with whom she had a son named Denardo, who has come to play drums regularly with both his mother's and his father's bands. Nineteen sixty-three was an important year for Cortez's relation to the Civil Rights movement; she traveled to Mississippi to work with Fannie Lou Hamer, the great civil rights activist who challenged voting restrictions for blacks. (Cortez composed an elegy for Hamer in the late 1970s, "Big Fine Woman from Rueville.") By 1964, after a divorce from Coleman, Cortez had co-founded the Watts Repertory Theatre Company, for which she served as artistic director until 1970. Directing plays, acting, and reading poetry, Cortez developed her early poetry within this venue of communal performance; most of the pieces in her first volume of poetry, *Pissstained Stairs and the Monkey Man's Wares* (1969) were written for the Watts Repertory to perform, and in the mid-1960s she also began composing and recording her poems with music.

In 1972 Cortez formed her own publishing company, Bola Press. She was a teacher and writer-in-residence at Rutgers University from 1977 to 1983. Cortez has traveled and read her poetry throughout the Caribbean, Latin America, Africa, and Europe. She has produced stunning recordings of many of her works, among them *There It Is* (1982) and *Maintain Control* (1986). Her books of poetry include *Festivals and Funerals* (1971) and *On the Imperial Highway: New and Selected Poems* (2008). She has received numerous awards, including an American Book Award for *Mouth on Paper* (1980); a New York Foundation for the Arts Award (1987); and the Langston Hughes Medal (2001). Cortez formed, along with Ghana-born Zimbabwe resident Ama Ata Aidoo, the Organization of Women Writers of Africa (OWWA).

Wide-ranging in theme and form, Cortez's poems display a persistent ability to disturb convention, stir remembrance, and spark response that is at once political and spiritual. "How Long Has Trane Been Gone" subtly suggests the African American mode of call-and-response to cultivate the reader's participation in collective explorations of black identity. With Coltrane "gone," a "willed" remembrance is required of the audience members for the project of communal restoration after searing loss to begin. Positing Trane as the site of an essential being, the poem offers possibilities of communal liberation that are continually deferred ("How long / Have black people been gone") until the loss of Coltrane becomes a powerful instigation for shared innovation. If Coltrane is apotheosized into a spectral symbol of iconic nationalism, the poem warns, the potential of the community for engaged revitalization can be squandered. And yet what remains strong within this threat of miscast worship is the speaker's own summons to common voice—"Now tell me abut the good things / I'm telling / you about / John Coltrane"—the voice that Cortez kept strong through a lifetime of dazzling poetic performance.

How Long Has Trane Been Gone[1]

Tell me about the good things
you clappin & laughin

Will you remember
or will you forget

Forget about the good things
like Blues & Jazz being black
Yeah Black Music
all about you

And the musicians that
write & play about you
a black brother groanin
a black sister moanin
& beautiful black children
ragged . . . underfed laughin
not knowin

Will you remember their names
or do they have no names
no lives—only products
to be used when you wanna
dance fuck & cry

You takin—they givin
You livin—they
creating starving dying
trying to make a better tomorrow
Giving you & your children a history
But what do you care about
history—Black History
and John Coltrane

No
All you wanna do
is pat your foot
sip a drink & pretend
with your head bobbin up & down
What do you care about acoustics
bad microphones or out-of-tune pianos
& noise
You the club owners & disc jockeys
made a deal didn't you
a deal about Black Music
& you really don't give
a shit long as you take[2]

1. Cf. blues standard "How Long, How Long Blues" as performed in 1928 by American blues singer-songwriter Leroy Carr (1905–1935), which begins: "How long, baby how long / Has that evening train been gone / How long, how long, baby how long." "Trane": John Coltrane (1926–1967), African American avant-garde jazz saxophonist.
2. I.e., take a profit.

There was a time
when KGFJ[3] played all black music
from Bird to Johnny Ace[4]
on show after show
but what happened
I'll tell you what happened
they divided black music
doubled the money
& left us split again
is what happened

John Coltrane's dead & some
of you
have yet to hear him play
How long how long has that Trane been gone

and how many more Tranes will go
before you understand your life
John Coltrane who had the whole of
life wrapped up in B flat
John Coltrane like Malcolm[5]
True image of Black Masculinity

Now tell me about the good things
I'm telling you about
John Coltrane

A name that should ring
throughout the projects[6] mothers
Mothers with sons
who need John Coltrane
Need the warm arm of his music
like words from a Father
words of Comfort
words of Africa
words of Welcome
How long how long has that Trane been gone

John palpitating love notes
in a lost-found nation[7]
within a nation
His music resounding discovery
signed Always
John Coltrane

3. Radio station in Los Angeles dubbed a "Negro-appeal" station in the 1920s and 1930s when it began to employ black announcers and play African American music; the station's call letters stood for "Keeping Good Folks Joyful."
4. Born John Marshall Alexander Jr. (1929–1954), Ace was an American rhythm-and-blues singer in the early 1950s who shot himself while playing Russian roulette backstage at a concert. "Bird": Charles Parker Jr. (1920–1955), jazz saxophonist and composer, a founding figure of bebop and a major influence on the next wave of avant-garde jazz musicians, including Coltrane and Cortez's first husband, saxophonist Ornette Coleman (b. 1930).
5. Malcolm X (1925–1965), powerful black leader of the early 1960s, minister of the Nation of Islam from 1952–1964 and later founder of the Organization of Afro-American Unity.
6. Public housing.
7. I.e., the African American religion known as the Nation of Islam, founded by Wallace Fard Muhammad (1877–?), author of *Teaching for the Lost Found Nation of Islam in a Mathematical Way* (c. 1932).

Rip those dead white people off
your walls Black People
black people whose walls
should be a hall
A Black Hall Of Fame 85
so our children will know
will know & be proud
Proud to say I'm from Parker City—Coltrane City—Ornette City
Pharoah City living on Holiday street next to
James Brown[8] park in the State of Malcolm 90

How Long
how long
will it take for you to understand
that Tranes been gone
riding in a portable radio 95
next to your son who's lonely
Who walks walks walks into nothing
no city no state no home no Nothing
how long
How long 100
Have black people been gone

1969

8. Popular soul singer (b. 1928). Ferrell "Pharoah" Sanders (b. 1940), tenor saxophonist who played in Coltrane's quartet from 1965 to 1967. Billie Holiday (1915–1959), jazz singer.

LARRY NEAL
1937–1981

Poet, essayist, theorist, editor, playwright, literary and music critic, pianist and flutist, filmmaker, screenwriter, folklorist, scholar, teacher, Larry Neal was the intellectual leader of the Black Arts movement. One of the most subtle theorists of the era's articulation of aesthetics and politics and a leading practitioner of its many expressive forms, Neal is remembered especially for a series of incisive essays produced in the decade from the mid-1960s to the mid-1970s that not only gave the Black Arts movement its name and aspects of its distinctive style, but also provided, in sinewy prose, cogent declarations of its philosophical foundations, cultural conditions, and revolutionary aspirations.

The oldest of five sons, Lawrence Paul Neal was born on September 5, 1937, in Atlanta, Georgia, to Woodie and Maggie Neal. Both parents were strong influences on Neal and nurtured him with a rich sense of cultural inheritance. In a "personal note" attached to his second volume of poetry, *Hoodoo Hollerin' Bebop Ghosts* (1971), Neal writes of his father as the first nationalist he ever knew, a man who had less than a high school education but was exceptionally well-read, insistent on self-reliance and practicality, and "in the most memorable sense of the term, say in the tradition of Walter White, Marcus Garvey, and A. J. Rodgers, a 'race man.'" If his father gave him a political and legal education (Woodie Neal,